

Prioritization and Delegation

A repeatable decision ladder for exam items and clinical communication.

Priority ladder - Immediate threats to airway, breathing, circulation, safety, or acute neurologic status. - Unstable before stable; acute/unexpected before chronic/expected. - Actual problems often before risk, unless the risk is immediate and catastrophic.	Delegation check - Right task, circumstance, person, direction/communication, supervision/evaluation. - Assessment, nursing judgment, teaching, and evaluation generally remain with the licensed nurse at the appropriate level. - Scope varies by role, state, and facility.
Question clue - Ask what can harm the client first. - Choose the least restrictive effective safety action. - If data are missing, assess before intervening unless delay is dangerous.	

Reviewed 2026-07-13 - Source: National Council of State Boards of Nursing - <https://www.ncsbn.org/publications/2026-nclex-pn-test-plan>
Study aid only. Verify current references, instructor guidance, scope, orders, and facility policy.